Bridging the Emotional Disconnect

Connecting Parents • Supporting Children

The Problem

Calls between migrant parents and left-behind children default to logistics, not closeness. The ordinary daily warmth a child needs gets lost across the distance.



66.9 million
left-behind children in China, 41.8 million of them in rural areas (NBS, UNICEF & UNFPA, 2023).

> 70%
of parent-child calls default to logistics (Madianou & Miller, 2011).

> 85%
higher risk of anxiety, and 52% higher risk of depression, among left-behind children (Fellmeth et al., 2018).

About Us

Team SpyKids is six UQ interaction design students building Baobei: a companion bear and app that help migrant parents stay close to the children they've left behind.

Our design decisions come from interviews with caregivers and teachers, video interaction analysis, and literature on left-behind children.

Our Process

Milestone 2 brings the bear and the parent app together:

- Squeeze the left paw to listen
- Squeeze the right paw to reply
- The heart glows when a message arrives
- Parents pair the bear once from the app

We interviewed adult caregivers and teachers, not children directly, as our ethics protocol requires.

Contact Us

+61-421 367 873

R39A-208 (GP North) | University of Queensland | Brisbane | QLD



From Insight to Design



Emotional masking → Embodied familiarity

a felt presence, not a call to answer.



No shared context → Asynchronous, personalised micro-interactions

voice notes, not scheduled calls.



Caregiver burden → Caregiver-light by design

no app, no charging, no cables.



Stigma sensitivity→ Playful, not clinical

a toy children want, not a tracker they're given.

How Baobei works



1

Parent sends care.

Record a voice note or a lullaby in your own voice, or tap Light up.

2



Parent sends care.

The bear checks in over Wi-Fi and saves the message on its card, so a dropped connection loses nothing.

3



The heart glows

The child squeezes the left paw to listen, whenever they're ready

4



The child replies

Squeezing the right paw records a voice note, which arrives in the parent's app.

Key Features

Voice notes, both ways

Parents send voice notes and lullabies. Children reply in their own voice.

Light up the heart

One tap makes the bear's heart glow: a quiet "thinking of you".

Child-led recording

The mic only listens when the child squeezes the right paw. Never otherwise.

No silence shown

The bear never shows whether a parent has replied. Reminders go to the parent only.

Works on patchy Wi-Fi

Messages wait safely on the bear and sync when the connection returns.

Inside the Physical Build

